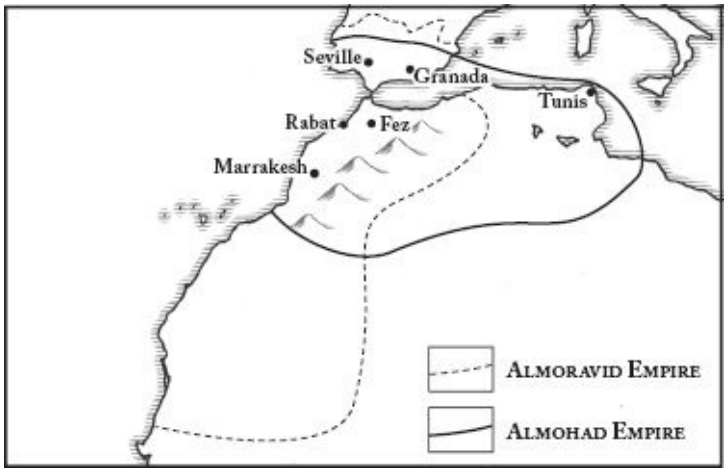
1146 had commanded all Jews (and any Christians who might be living in the Muslim areas) to convert to Islam, but even Jews who converted were required to wear distinctive black tunics and black caps to set them apart. As Almohad power in Spain grew, the decree was more and more often enforced. "[I am] like one who is drowning," Maimon ben Joseph wrote, just before leaving his home. "We are almost totally immersed. . . . Overwhelmed with humiliation, blamed and despised, the seas of captivity surround us and we are submerged in its depths."[6]

Conditions in the Christian kingdoms were only slightly better; and ben Joseph's family, like many others, crossed over to the North African coast. Eventually they reached Egypt and settled there, under the more benevolent government of Saladin. There, ben Joseph's older son Maimonides began to practice as a physician. He also started work on a massive, fourteen-volume summary of Jewish law, which he hoped would give the scattered and perplexed Jews a guide for living in troubled times.

Meanwhile, the Almohad grip on North Africa had tightened.



13.2 The Almohad Empire

The Almohad caliph 'Abd al-Mu'min had brought all of North Africa under his control: "Through him," wrote the Almohad historian al-Marrakushi, "God stamped out disbelief in Ifriqiya." He was planning a massive transfer of forces over to the Spanish peninsula, in preparation for a full-scale assault on the Christian resistance.[7]

But in 1163, he died before launching his invasion. He had fathered fifteen sons, so for several years his son and successor Yusuf I had to spend most of his strength fighting off brotherly challenges to his caliphate. Struggles on the Spanish peninsula continued, small army against small army, border spats and guerrilla warfare. The unsettled times allowed mercenaries